

People's Governor

Unlike most governors, Gopalkrishna Gandhi is pro-active and chooses to make strong statements against the state Government when he sees that the people he governs are compromised

■ By Swagata Sen

Kolkata, like most state capitals, has its own siren culture. Political bigwigs merit a road block for a quarter of an hour with a siren that can be heard from miles. So when a car stops at a crossing, with just a single pilot car preceding it, the mandatory red light twirling but the siren conspicuously absent, you tend to not pay much attention. Unless, inside the car, is the man who deserves this brouhaha the most, West Bengal Governor Gopalkrishna Gandhi, the grandson of the Mahatma.

As a person, Gandhi believes in understatement. He thinks nothing of attending a classroom lecture because he is interested in the subject being taught, and he quietly attends plays in other cities without the performers being aware of his presence. With an impeccable lineage, brilliant academic credentials, distinguished career and disciplined integrity, he is more clued in to the grassroots problems of West Bengal than many of its local leaders. Most governors are political appointees, content to treat their appointment as a sinecure and steering clear of controversy. Not so Gandhi. As the state Governor, he chooses to make strong statements when he sees that the people he governs are being compromised. "Enough is enough," he said to the press the day Nandigram was "recaptured" by CPI-M cadres. "The ardour of Deepavali has been dampened in the whole state by the events in Nandigram." Despite being criticised by leaders such as Biman Bose for his strong reactions which he chose to make public instead of holding discussions with the ruling party, Gandhi has decided to be where it matters—with the people of the state.

When the Governor visited Nandigram for the first time last week

CLUED IN: Gandhi consoling victims of violence in Nandigram

